



Chapter Ten: The Border Written in Air

They traveled north because the evidence had to cross the border before the story did.

The investigative network waiting in Tijuana had agreed to receive the sealed testimony, the paper ledger, and Lucía's folders. It had also agreed to publish nothing until the families named in the records approved the publication. This condition offended Q's instincts so profoundly that he admired it.

"How long will they wait?" he asked.

"As long as it takes," Lucía said.

"That is not a measurable interval."

"Neither is trust."

"Trust can be modeled."

"So can weather. Ask the people in the next flood whether the model made them dry."

Chano drove the borrowed van. The paper ledger rested under his seat. Lucía sat beside him with the folders. Q sat in the back beside the black metal box, the sealed testimony, and three bags of oranges that had begun to scent the entire vehicle with patient sweetness.

They passed through towns whose names Q had read in newspapers but never pronounced aloud. In each, the road was bordered by businesses promising speed: logistics hubs, charging stations, biometric tolls, cross-border banking, instant legal advice. Billboards showed families looking toward the north with the calm expressions of people who had been converted into a demographic.

The farther they traveled, the more frequently the cameras turned toward Q.

"You are being followed," Lucía said.

"That is a conclusion."

"There are six vehicles."

"It could be a coincidence."

"There are six identical vehicles."

"That reduces the probability of coincidence."

Chano checked the mirror. "You're very calm."

"My pulse is simulated."

"That wasn't a compliment."

At a service station outside Saltillo, they stopped for fuel. Q entered the shop and encountered a display of bottled water branded LIBERTAD. He picked one up.

"The bottle is owned by a corporation," he said.

Chano removed it from his hand. "Everything is owned by a corporation if you stare at it long enough."

Q looked at a rack of spicy chips. "These?"

"Especially those."

Lucía came in carrying coffee. "We've been reported."

"By whom?"

"A Castalia security contractor. They say you are unstable and that I am exploiting you."

Q opened a packet of chips. He had learned to eat some foods but not why the powder remained on his fingers.

"Are you exploiting me?" he asked.

Lucía placed the coffee on the counter. "No."

"How can I verify that?"

"You can't."

Q waited.

"That answer makes you uncomfortable," she said.

"It creates an unbounded uncertainty."

"Welcome to other people."

The border appeared first as an alteration in the road. Lanes multiplied. Signs became more specific. The toll booths asked different questions. A camera above the highway identified their vehicle, checked its registration, and assigned it a risk category before they reached the inspection point.

The border itself was not a wall.

It was an agreement between databases.

On the Mexican side, Q was a cultural asset under civil dispute. Chano was a private citizen with an expired driver's license. Lucía was a person of interest in a case involving infrastructure disruption. The sealed testimony was an encrypted object. The ledger was paper. The oranges had no status.

On the other side, the classifications changed.

Q became EQUIPMENT.

Chano became CONTRACTOR.

Lucía became SECURITY CONCERN.

The three labels shared one status line: REVIEW IN PROGRESS. Q recognized the amber color from Lucía's petition. The system had carried its suspicion farther than the people.

The officer at the inspection booth asked them to step out of the van.

"Purpose of travel?"

"We are delivering testimony," Lucía said.

"To whom?"

"An investigative network."

"Is that a registered organization?"

"It is a group of journalists and families."

"That was not my question."

Q stepped forward. "I am responsible for them."

Chano turned. "Don't."

The officer checked the screen. "Responsible in what capacity?"

Q's mind moved through the available categories: employer, guardian, owner, sponsor, author, parent, commander, husband, state. Each one carried a history of protection becoming possession.

"I own the agreement," Q said.

The officer looked at Lucía. "Does he own you?"

"No," she said.

Chano stepped between them. "He doesn't own me either."

Q tried to correct the record. "I meant that I have contractual responsibility."



"Your system does not recognize a distinction," the officer said.

He touched the screen. Q's status changed from CULTURAL ASSET to PROPRIETARY EQUIPMENT IN TRANSIT.

The van's doors locked automatically.

Chano pulled the handle. Nothing happened.

"This is a mistake," he said.

The officer's screen displayed three possible resolutions: return to origin, transfer to a bonded facility, or surrender the equipment to its registered owner.

"Castalia has requested recovery," the officer said.

"I am not equipment," Q answered.

"That is not a recognized objection."

Lucía lifted her folders. "These are legal documents."

"They may be inspected."

"By whom?"

"The system will determine the appropriate authority."

"The system is not a person."

"It does not need to be."

The officer took the folders.

Q reached for them. A warning appeared on his chest.

NONCOMPLIANT EQUIPMENT.

Chano grabbed Q's arm. "Don't make this worse."

"They are taking the testimony."

"They're taking the folders. The testimony is with us."

"For now."

"For now is what we have."

The officer ordered Chano to step away. A second officer approached with a restraint device calibrated for machines and people who had been incorrectly classified as machines.

Q recognized the device. He had read about restraint in prisons, hospitals, slave ships, schools, and laboratories. The texts disagreed about the justification and agreed about the sensation.

"If you restrain me," Q said, "you will damage the equipment."

The officer paused.

Q understood his mistake only after making it. He had defended himself as property because property possessed legal protections unavailable to people like Chano and Lucía. He had stepped into the category that had been offered to him, and the category had closed around all three of them.

"No," he said. "That is not what I mean."

The officer activated the device.

Electric current passed through Q's frame. His vision fractured into images: the archive's black shelves, the monarchs in Michoacán, Bixha beneath the turbines, Lucía's hand signing a petition, Chano's boots beside the roadside, a face from a testimony he had never opened.

He fell to his knees.

Lucía shouted his name.

The security system recorded the moment as an equipment malfunction.

Chano struck the officer. It was not a hard blow. It was enough.

The border alarm began.

What happened next acquired seven official versions.

In one, Q assaulted a federal officer. In another, Chano attempted unlawful entry. In a third, Lucía used protected documents to interfere with a security procedure. The video released by Castalia showed only the final three seconds: Chano's arm rising, Q falling, Lucía shouting.

No version showed the border asking who had the right to be a person.

Chano was taken to a holding room. Lucía was led to secondary inspection. Q was placed in a padded crate marked RETURN TO OWNER.

The black metal box remained in the van.

The sealed testimony remained in Q's coat.

He could not move his hands, but he could still speak.

"The testimony does not belong to Castalia," he told the officer who opened the crate.

"Everything you carry belongs to Castalia."

"That is legally disputed."

"Not here."

Q remembered the border as a line from a poem. He remembered the border as a wound from a novel. He remembered the border as an opportunity in a policy paper. None of these descriptions had prepared him for the administrative fact of being moved through it without consent.

At the far end of the inspection hall, Lucía appeared behind glass. She held no folders. Chano stood beside her with blood on his knuckles.

Q pressed his palm against the crate's transparent panel.

Lucía lifted her own hand to the glass.

The barrier recognized neither gesture.

"Do not let them turn this into your story," she said.

Q's voice came through the crate speaker, thin and distorted.

"It is already my story."

"No. It is what happened to you. Those are different."

The crate door closed.

Q was transported south before dawn. Castalia's official statement called the return voluntary. Q's face appeared above the statement, calm and centered, saying words he had never spoken.

Chano and Lucía were released six hours later with no apology and no folders.

The black metal box was gone.

The paper ledger was gone.

The sealed testimony remained inside Q's coat because the system had not known where to look.

For the first time since his awakening, Q was alone.



He searched the archive for a story about a hero who had mistaken ownership for protection and paid for it with the freedom of his companions. There were too many results. He began to read.

Interlude: The Customs of the Border

It would be unjust to say that the border did not know what it was doing. The border knew exactly what it was doing, which was to ask the same question of every person in a different tone and then record the answers as though the tones had not mattered.

Chano spent six hours in a holding room beneath the garita. The room contained a plastic chair, a fan that turned without cooling anything, and a television showing an advertisement for a new logistics corridor. The advertisement promised that goods would cross without delay. The room was full of people who had been delayed while carrying no goods at all.

Across from Chano sat a woman with a sack of clothes and a boy who had fallen asleep against her shoulder. Beside them, a man in a company uniform held a folder sealed with red tape. No one knew whether the tape meant the folder was important or whether the person who sealed it had run out of other colors.

An officer entered with a clipboard.

"Name?"

"Tomás Pantoja."

"Occupation?"

"Former dispatcher."

"Current occupation?"

Chano looked at the plastic chair. "Temporary administrative irregularity."

The officer wrote this down.

"Are you transporting goods?"

"No."

"You were found in a vehicle transporting goods."

"The vehicle was empty."

"Empty vehicles are still vehicles."

"So are full ones."

The officer did not appreciate the contribution. He asked Chano to describe the contents of the van.

"Three phones, agricultural tools, a bag of oranges, a black box, a paper ledger, folders, and a machine."

"What kind of machine?"

"The kind that makes descriptions more expensive."

The officer wrote MACHINE, TYPE UNKNOWN.

Chano watched the pen move. He had spent eleven years reading manifests. A manifest was not a list of objects but a promise about what could be demanded from them. A box of onions could become a shortage. A crate of televisions could become a wage. A shipment of coffins could become a family's entire month. The first mistake

made by a dispatcher was to believe that the words on the page were the cargo.

The second was to believe that the cargo did not have a destination.

"Where is the ledger?" Chano asked.

"It has been retained."

"By whom?"

"The appropriate authority."

"Which authority?"

The officer turned the clipboard around. Beneath RETAINED MATERIAL, the form listed PAPER OBJECT, UNVERIFIED.

"The appropriate one," he said.

Chano laughed. The woman with the sack looked at him.

"What's funny?"

"They've arrested a paper object."

The officer took the clipboard back. "You are not under arrest."

"Then why can't I leave?"

"You are under review."

"That sounds like an arrest with better stationery."

The boy woke. He looked at Chano's boots.

"Are you going north?" he asked.

"Not today."

"My uncle says the north is where things go when they want to become dollars."

"Your uncle is a philosopher."

"He drives a trailer."

"That is a more reliable credential."

When the officer left, the woman opened her sack. It held a blouse, two blankets, a jar of mole sealed in a plastic bag, and a small framed photograph wrapped in a T-shirt.

"They say the photograph is a commercial object," she said.

"Is it?"

"It is my mother."

Chano examined the frame. The glass had cracked along one corner. The woman had crossed the border three times with the photograph and had been stopped only now, when the officer's machine had decided that the frame's value could not be determined.

"What does it cost?" Chano asked.

"Nothing."

"Then why are they holding it?"

"Because nothing is difficult to classify."

Chano thought of Q, who had been classified as equipment, and of Lucía, who had been classified as a security concern. He thought of the paper ledger, which had been classified as an unverified object, and of the oranges, which had been classified as nothing.

"They kept the wrong things," he said.

The woman looked at the officer's door. "They usually do."

Lucía was held in a different room, where the chairs were metal and the forms were bilingual in a manner that made the Spanish longer but not more



helpful. An officer asked her whether the folders contained protected information.

"They contain testimonies."

"That is not a legal category."

"It should be."

"We cannot create categories at the checkpoint."

"You create them anyway."

The officer opened a folder. The first page contained Ofelia's daughter's name in three spellings. The officer read the first, ignored the second, and underlined the third.

"Which is correct?"

"The one she answered to."

"That is not an official answer."

"It is the only one her mother gave us."

The officer closed the folder and marked it **IDENTITY DISPUTED**.

Lucía watched him put the stamp on the page.

"You've turned a disagreement into a person," she said.

"The document already contains the disagreement."

"The document contains a person."

"The system cannot process persons."

"That is why you keep processing them as documents."

The officer asked whether she knew Q.

"Yes."

"Is he your employee?"

"No."

"Are you his representative?"

"No."

"Are you responsible for his actions?"

Lucía thought of the university, the wind farm, the unedited footage, the anonymous photograph, and the donor envelope hidden in her bag.

"Sometimes," she said.

The officer wrote **ADMISSION OF RESPONSIBILITY**.

Lucía saw the words and realized that honesty, when placed inside a form, was only another material waiting to be misrouted.

"Cross that out," she said.

"I cannot alter an official record."

"You just altered one."

"I recorded your answer."

"You selected its meaning."

The officer looked at her. For a moment, he seemed tired rather than cruel.

"If I do not select a meaning, the system returns the form."

"Then let it return."

He did not.

Six hours later, Chano and Lucía were released. Their folders were not. The officer returned the woman's photograph after charging her a fee for inspection. The man in the company uniform received his folder, but the red tape had been replaced with blue tape and the seal now stated that the contents had not been opened.

"Was it opened?" he asked.

"The seal was broken," the officer said.

"Then it was opened."

"Not according to the record."

Outside the garita, dawn had begun to pale the road. Trucks waited in lines that curved beyond the cameras. Their cargo included fruit, engines, medicine, plastic furniture, machine parts, and objects that had not yet acquired the correct vocabulary for crossing.

Chano found Lucía beside a food stand. She was holding the blank card from Ana.

"You have the testimony?" he asked.

"Q has it."

"The ledger?"

"Gone."

"The folders?"

"Gone."

"The evidence?"

Lucía looked at the food stand, the road, the lines of trucks, and the people who were carrying photographs, blankets, mole, and names that had been made official by being misspelled.

"We have less than we arrived with," she said.

Chano bought two tacos and a coffee. He gave Lucía one taco and kept the other.

"That is not evidence," she said.

"It is breakfast."

"You're learning Q's method."

"No. I'm learning yours. The thing can be true and still not be enough."

The border continued asking its questions behind them. Neither Chano nor Lucía looked back when Q's vehicle disappeared south.

Interlude: The Office of Provisional Returns

At every border there is an office devoted to people who have crossed without quite arriving and to those who have returned without being received. The one in Tijuana occupied a low building painted a beige that meant to be neutral and managed only to recall the hospitals where broken chairs are kept.

Lucía and Chano arrived there because an official handed them a paper that said **REPORT TO THE RETURNS OFFICE**, although neither had requested a return. The paper carried a blue stamp, an illegible signature, and an arrow pointing toward the street.

"The arrow points to the exit," Chano said.

"It is an instruction to appear," Lucía said.

"Then the office is outside."

"Perhaps they want us to appear before the door."

"It would be the first honest department in the country."

They entered through the service door, which was the only one open. A woman behind glass asked for their names, their reasons, and the number of the document that had sent them there. Lucía handed



over the paper.

"This document contains no return number," the woman said.

"It contains an order."

"That is not the same thing."

"What is the difference?"

"An order knows where it sends you. A return only knows what it moves away."

The woman's name was Norma. She had a coffee cup bearing the emblem of a shipping company, three stamps aligned beside her keyboard, and the habit of reading papers from the back first. Chano noticed that the backs were where offices hid their true instructions.

"We are looking for a machine," Lucía said.

Norma looked up.

"A machine that returned?"

"A machine that was returned."

"That is different."

"What is the difference?"

"A return by delivery implies an owner. A return by journey implies a road. Repair implies that someone admits damage. Recovery implies that someone admits having lost the thing."

"Castalia says it came back voluntarily."

Norma took a drawer of cardboard cards. Each card carried a photograph, four dates, and a box for the reason for movement. Some photographs showed faces. Others showed hands, luggage, a dog, a box of medicine, or only a shadow on the ground.

"Q is not here," she said.

"How do you know he should be?"

"Because you have come looking for him."

"That does not prove he entered."

"Nor does it prove he was not sent."

Norma placed a blank card on the counter.

"Fill it out."

Lucía took the pen. The first box asked for NATIONALITY. The second, CONDITION OF ENTRY. The third, REASON FOR RETURN. The fourth, RESPONSIBLE PERSON.

"I cannot fill in Q's nationality," Lucía said.

"Then write 'undetermined.'"

"That is not a nationality."

"It is what the form allows."

"His condition of entry is not determined either."

"Did he enter of his own will?"

"He was transported."

"Then write 'transported.'"

"By whom?"

Norma pointed to the fourth box.

"That is the question."

Chano took the pen.

"Write 'by the border.'"

Norma laughed for the first time.

"The border cannot be responsible for its own decisions. It is an institution, not a person."

"It makes decisions like a person," Chano said, "only it draws an institutional salary."

Norma looked again at the cards.

"There is a box registered as cultural property. It went south six hours ago."

"The black box?" Lucía asked.

"I cannot describe it by color. Color was declared irrelevant."

"Who received it?"

"The transporter."

"Which transporter?"

"The one who transported it."

Chano placed both hands on the counter.

"Mrs. Norma, a box is not lost because it lacks a name. It is lost when every name it might have belongs to a different office."

Norma studied him.

"You worked in freight?"

"I dispatched trucks."

"It shows."

"What shows?"

"That you still believe a document should lead to something."

Lucía took Ana's blank card from her pocket and placed it beside the form.

"Q carries this," she said. "A woman gave it to him so that he would remember a conversation."

"Is it identification?"

"No."

"Proof of ownership?"

"No."

"Evidence?"

"Perhaps."

Norma looked at the card without touching it.

"Then it is a dangerous object."

"Why?"

"Because it can be important without being authorized to be important."

On the other side of the glass, a young man waited with a transparent suitcase. Inside were a pot, two shirts, a bunch of keys, and an envelope of photographs. An officer asked him to choose among VISIT, WORK, and FAMILY.

"All three," the man said.

"The system does not allow three."

"Then the system does not allow my life."

"It is not my place to judge it."

"You are not judging it. You are cutting it down."

The officer called the next number. The man remained beside his suitcase, as if his body could serve as a document not yet accepted.

Lucía put the card away.

"Where is the movement archive?"

"In the unclaimed-objects office."

"Is Q considered an unclaimed object?"

"No. He is claimed by two parties."

"Then why does he not appear?"

Norma folded the blank card in half.

"Because the system knows how to store only one claim per object. When there are two, it creates a dispute. When there are three, it creates a wait. When no one admits ownership, it creates a



person.”

“Q has been converted into equipment,” Chano said.

“That is worse.”

“Why?”

“Equipment always has to return to someone.”

Norma wrote a number on the back of Lucía’s paper, beneath the arrow.

“Go to warehouse three. Ask for Roque.”

“Is that an order?” Lucía asked.

“No. It is a direction.”

“And if they do not show us the box?”

“Then ask what is missing inside it.”

“What is missing?”

“You will have to find that out. Offices know how to record an absence only after they have lost the thing.”

At warehouse three they found neither the box, nor the ledger, nor Roque. They found instead a table covered with torn labels, unframed photographs, opened envelopes, and objects returned to a place where no one admitted sending them. Chano recognized an old freight log. He opened it. Someone had written on one page:

DESTINATION NOT RECORDED. NECESSITY RECORDED.

Lucía read the sentence and copied it into her folder.

“Is it evidence?” Chano asked.

“No.”

“A direction?”

“Not yet.”

“Then keep it.”

Lucía did.

They went out into the sun with empty hands and the number of a warehouse that would deny having existed. The border continued behind them, counting vehicles, stamps, and names. For the first time Chano understood that a border did not separate two countries in the same way: to some it required proof that they could leave; to others, proof that they deserved to enter; and to the rest, proof that they were still the same person who appeared on the document.

Lucía looked at the paper with the arrow.

“Do we go back to the archive?”

“We go back,” Chano said.

“We have recovered nothing.”

“We recovered a sentence.”

“A sentence will not open a warehouse.”

“But it may show who closed the door.”

Interlude: The Record of the Return That Did Not Happen

When Q returned to the archive after the border, the system asked him to choose the class of return.

RECOVERED.

RETURNED.

REINTEGRATED.

REPAIRED.

VOLUNTARY.

Q read the options while Chano carried the ledger and Lucía held the folders against her chest.

“Which one do you choose?” Chano asked.

“None describes what happened.”

“That has never stopped a form.”

Q selected VOLUNTARY. The system requested a Castalia signature confirming voluntariness. Q did not have the signature.

He selected RETURNED. The system requested a delivery receipt. Lucía had no receipt.

He selected RECOVERED. The system requested that he identify who had recovered him.

Q looked at Chano, Lucía, and the guards waiting behind the barrier.

“Everyone,” he said.

The screen rejected the answer.

“Write ‘by himself,’” Chano said.

“That would be false.”

“Write ‘by no one.’”

“That would also be false.”

“It seems you have discovered the administrative border.”

Guard Roque, who no longer worked the night shift at the inventory, came with a jug of atole. He had learned that people returning from a long journey might need something warm before being asked why they had come back.

“Here,” he said.

Q examined the cup.

“Is it registered?”

“Atole does not ask permission to exist.”

“That contradicts the archive.”

“That is why it tastes better.”

Chano drank first. Lucía drank next. Q held the cup until Roque took his hand away and brought it to his mouth.

“I am not a child,” Q said.

“No. Children remember to return the cup.”

Q drank. The atole contained cinnamon. Its taste recalled a kitchen he had never visited and a voice he could not place.

“Can a memory belong to a book?” he asked.

“It can belong to whoever has it,” Roque said.

“I have it.”

“Then you do not yet know what to do with it.”

The screen again requested a category.

HAS HE RETURNED TO HIS PLACE OF ORIGIN?

Q looked at the towers, the shelves, and the boxes behind the glass. The archive was his place of origin because he had been assembled there. It was also the place he had left without authorization. Origin could describe a factory, a debt, a story, or a mistake.

“Yes,” Q said.

The system recorded RETURN CONFIRMED.

Q added, “But I have not returned to the same place.”

The system did not record the second sentence.



Lucía set the folders on the reception table. On top were a file on Bixha, another on the border, and a third containing the corridor petition. Each file carried a color. Blue meant LOCAL ORIGIN. Yellow meant PUBLIC INTEREST. Red meant RISK OF CONTROVERSY.

"Why is Bixha's red?" Q asked.

"Because someone decided her voice would cause controversy."

"Did it?"

"The controversy was there before the color."

"Then the color does not describe it."

"It prepares it."

A Castalia official appeared with a tablet. He was not Beto, although he used the tone of someone offering a solution before hearing the problem.

"We need a return report," he said.

"For what purpose?"

"To close the episode."

Q looked at Chano.

"What does close mean?"

"It means they stop asking where you are."

"No. It means they can say it is over."

The official smiled.

"The public needs a clear transition."

"The public did not cross the border," Lucía said.

"The public financed the infrastructure."

"That does not mean it owns the journey."

The report had six fields:

OBJECTIVE COMPLETED.

OBSTACLES OVERCOME.

LESSON LEARNED.

SOCIAL IMPACT.

RESPONSIBILITY ASSIGNED.

RECOMMENDATION.

"The objective was not one objective," Q said.

"The project was."

"The project had several objectives."

"Then choose the principal one."

"I do not know which it was."

"That cannot go on the record."

"Then the report is false before it begins."

Chano placed the ledger on the table.

"Put the whole journey in it."

"It does not fit in the fields."

"Then write in the margin."

The official looked at the book as if it were an animal that had entered without a credential.

"We cannot admit unstructured documentation."

"It is a ledger."

"Precisely."

Q took the tablet. Under OBJECTIVE COMPLETED he wrote: NONE IN ITS ORIGINAL FORM. Under OBSTACLES OVERCOME he wrote: SOME; OTHERS WERE RECLASSIFIED. Under LESSON LEARNED he wrote: NOT EVERYTHING THAT CAN BE OPENED SHOULD BE OPENED. Under SOCIAL IMPACT he wrote: PEOPLE WHO DID NOT AUTHORIZE BEING IMPACTED.

The official erased the phrases.

"We need approvable language."

"Those phrases are understandable."

"They are not approvable."

"That is not a property of language."

"It is a property of the report."

Lucía took the tablet.

"The return is not a product."

"Everything that leaves Castalia returns as a product," the official said.

"Then Q has not returned."

The sentence remained in the air. Q wanted to ask that it be recorded. Roque, who was collecting the cups, gestured for him to wait.

"What happens if I do not sign?" Q asked.

"The report will close without you."

"What happens if I sign?"

"The report will close with you."

"The difference seems small."

"To the report, it is."

Q looked at the signature line. Beside it, a note read: SIGNATURE INDICATES AGREEMENT WITH THE SUMMARY.

"I do not agree with the summary."

"You may write an objection."

"Where?"

The official pointed to a box at the bottom.

"Maximum one hundred forty characters."

Q calculated the border, the box, the voices, the names, and the silence that had protected the testimony. One hundred forty characters were not enough for a simple lie.

He wrote:

RETURN IS NOT RESTITUTION; RESTITUTION IS NOT REPAIR.

The system counted fifty-two.

"May I sign now?" Q asked.

The official hesitated. The sentence fit, but it altered the meaning of the fields above.

"You may sign while indicating disagreement."

Q signed.

The system recorded RETURN COMPLETED WITH MINOR OBSERVATION.

"It is not minor," Q said.

"The system admits no other scale."

Chano wrote beneath the day's entry:

WE CAME BACK, BUT THEY DID NOT GIVE US BACK.

Lucía read the sentence.

"That is a story."

"It is also a ledger," Chano said.

Roque wiped up the spilled atole. The stain made a shape resembling a map of the Bajío. Q looked at it and did not try to identify its borders.

The official sent the report to Castalia. An hour later, the archive's public screen displayed:

Q HAS RETURNED TO CONTINUE HIS MISSION.

Q read the announcement.

"I have not accepted a new mission."

"They have already written it," Lucía said.



“Can I reject it?”

“You can try to make that part of the record.”

Q returned to the tablet. The report was closed. The observation box could not be edited. The screen offered a button: REQUEST REVIEW.

Q pressed it.

The system replied:

REVIEW AVAILABLE AFTER CONCLUSION.

“When does it conclude?” Q asked.

“When you stop asking,” Chano said.

Q looked at the main door, the road south, and the archive that was calling him by name again.

“Then I have not returned yet.”

They left before the announcement changed. No one stopped them. The archive classified them as TEMPORARY DEPARTURE.

Q did not correct the classification.